The Hood

Amit Chaudhuri's meditative new novel—*Château Rouge*—explores Paris's 'Little Africa' through the eyes of a writer who arrives in the city for a residency

Q. How did *Château Rouge* come to be?
It was set into motion by a stray remark from my wife, meant to calm me when I was planning to vacate the apartment I found myself in, whose disrepair had taken me as much by surprise as the neighbourhood's shabbiness: 'This is where Hemingway would have lived if he'd been here today—not some fancy made-up place'. The remark translated the reality around me into the realm of the conceptual, giving it, paradoxically, fresh life: always the way my novels come into being, rather than from an urge to report on some bit of my biography.

Q. You write against the idea of the 'already known' city. Can you elaborate?
Everything is already known, not just Paris. Even the future is already known. You only write when you realise what's known is unfamiliar. With Paris, this takes on a cultural and historical frisson.

Q. Tell us about the subtle presence of race in the book.
The multiplicity of race and shade and physicality is concomitant with beauty. 'Glory be to God for dappled things – / For skies of couple-colour as a brinded cow', says [Gerard Manley] Hopkins. Paris reminds us that you can't find beauty in a museum.

Q. What role does Hemingway's *A Moveable Feast* play in the novel?
My wife gave me this book when we first met, and I never read it—until, in fact, I'd written *Château Rouge*. The book finds a home in my book as something that's available but unconsulted, at hand but not looked at, like so much that's precious in our lives.

—with Palash Krishna Mehrotra

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